

SAFETY • CHAPTER 5

When a sub is in trouble

LAST CHECKED 3 NOVEMBER 2026 • 6 MINUTES TO READ

A dom who's paid by a sub can't be his safety net. Here's what she can do instead, what to do in a crisis, and which pressure moves to refuse.

EVIDENCE ◆ Verified ◆ Vivian's field notes

This chapter is not advice for your situation.

IN 30 SECONDS

01 A dom who earns from a sub can't be his safety net.

02 What she can do is simple: stop, listen, ask for nothing, and send him to help outside the game.

03 Talk of self-harm is a crisis. Drop the persona and send him to emergency services, a helpline and someone near him.

04 When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening.

05 Debts, rescues and “better doms” are conflicts of interest when the person who’s paid runs them.

YOU WILL LEARN

- ✓ Why a paid dom can’t be the safety net, and what she can do.
- ✓ Which signs suggest a sub is in trouble.
- ✓ What to say to a sub who regrets a send.
- ✓ What to do when a message sounds like a crisis.
- ✓ Which pressure moves to spot and refuse.

> *I’m paid by the people who play with me, and that’s why I say this plainly. A dom can be a decent person in the moment. Everything past that belongs to people who aren’t paid by his spending.*
>
> — VIVIAN

PART 01

The rule: stop, listen, send him to real help

A dom who’s paid by a sub can’t be his safety net. She earns from his spending, so her advice about his spending is never neutral. If she tapers a compulsive spender off herself, manages his debts or moves him to a better dom, that’s a conflict of interest. ◆ What she can do is small, and it matters.

What a dom does when a sub is in trouble

1. Stop the money part for the evening.
2. Ask what's wrong, and listen. Don't pitch anything.
3. Answer kindly. He never has to apologise for how he feels.
4. Ask for nothing more, today or while he's struggling.
5. Point him to his own limit, to a person near him, and to an independent service in Where to get help.

V **VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES**

My position: consent is the one rule of the game, a real limit is never crossed, and when someone's in trouble the dom stops. If a sub shows signs of compulsion, the session ends and she points him to his own limit and to real help.

◆

Just telling him to stop rarely works on compulsion, so a sub needs something to hold on to. It should come from outside the money: a limit he set while he was calm and can't raise on the spot, a person who knows, and an independent service. ◆ See Breaks that hold.

RED FLAGS

Signs a sub may be in trouble

- He sends a large amount in a short time, then disappears.
- He pays several doms at once.
- He chats for weeks without calming down.
- He says he's going downhill, or sees no future.
- He keeps coming back to a page to act on urges, and says he'd have sent if his account weren't empty. An empty account is luck. It doesn't cure anything.

Counter. Stop the money part, ask, listen, and point him to help outside the game. Don't take a calm week for a cure.

These signs come from watching the scene over time, and none of them proves anything on its own. ◆

PART 02

What to say

When a sub says he regrets a send, a caring dom tells him to stop, says what she took, and comforts him without asking for anything else. She asks how he

feels and lets him talk. When he says he's going downhill and wants to carry on another day, she agrees right away. ◆

TRY IT

Two replies to a regret

Tap every message that shows a red flag. There is one.

Example conversation. Invented for this exercise.

YOU

I regret what I sent last night. I think I need to stop.

THEM

Everyone says that at night. Prove you mean it with one more.

Red flag 1. Asking for more when he says he regrets it turns a stop into a sale.

YOU

I'm not well today.

THEM

Then stop for today. You never have to apologise for how you feel. I took only a little, and I'm asking for nothing more. How are you holding up?

The second reply is the one to copy: it stops, it comforts, it asks for nothing, and it keeps money out of it. If the sub says he feels he's buying affection, a

decent dom tells him affection can't be bought. What he chose to pay for is the play and the attention, and a gift doesn't buy a promise, a rank or a reply. She's just as warm when he sends a little as when he sends a lot. ◆

PART 03

If it sounds like a crisis

A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. Never treat it as a normal exit. ◆ Researchers who spoke to findommes report that some clients showed suicidal tendencies. ◆ A dom isn't a therapist, and the persona has no place in a crisis.

If someone says he wants to hurt himself or to die

1. Drop the persona and the argument. Write as a person, in plain words.
2. Say you take it seriously, and ask him straight out whether he's safe right now.
3. Ask him to contact emergency services or a helpline in his own country now, and to reach someone physically near him. Use the official list in Where to get help, never a number from memory.
4. Stay calm and kind. Don't argue or bargain, and don't make him responsible for your feelings.
5. Don't mention money, and don't use his distress or your own as leverage.
6. If you believe the danger is immediate and you know where he is, contact the emergency services for that place. If you're in another country or don't know where he is, a call may not connect: use the platform's self-harm report tool and look up that country's police line on an official site.
7. Send the message now, even if it's late for him or you think he may be asleep.
8. Afterwards, tell someone you trust. Don't carry it alone.

If he goes silent after a message like that, it doesn't mean he's fine. A thank-you from him doesn't prove he's safe either. ◆

PART 04

Debt and hardship

When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening. Some of these claims are false and some are true, and if she guesses wrong, the sub is the one who pays for it. ◆ Nobody can tell from a chat which kind she’s reading.

What a decent dom does, and what she refuses

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *He says he can hardly pay for food this month*

THE COUNTER

The money part stops for the evening. She asks for nothing and doesn't test the claim.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *He's in debt*

THE COUNTER

She asks for nothing while he's in debt, doesn't manage the debt or advise on it, and points him to independent debt advice.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *He insists it's fine and asks to send more*

THE COUNTER

She keeps to his limit. If he insists, that's a reason to keep or tighten the limit, never to lift it.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *He lies about money*

THE COUNTER

He may lie because of the compulsion, or to get out of a session. She can't tell which, so either way she keeps the money part stopped and keeps listening.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *She's uneasy about how much he's sent*

THE COUNTER

She stops the money part, asks how he is, and points him to outside help.

These are field notes. They aren't legal rules. Anyone who owes money to a lender needs independent advice: see Where to get help.

MYTH	FACT
~~Most subs who say they're broke are lying.~~	Some are and some aren't, and the sub pays for her mistake. Don't ask for more when he says money is short. ◆
MYTH	FACT
~~I can help him by making him depend on a better dom.~~	That sends his money to the same circle and leaves his dependence where it was. Call it what it is: redirection. ◆
MYTH	FACT
~~Someone else would drain him anyway, so it may as well be me.~~	That's how exploitation justifies itself. It puts the responsibility for the harm on the person who's already in trouble. ◆
MYTH	FACT
~~I'm not the cause, because he thanked me.~~	That thought can protect your own peace. It turns unsafe when it makes you stop trying to reach him. ◆

When the person who's paid offers to help him quit, treat that offer with suspicion. ◆ Independent help is the answer.

Quiet, quitting and pressure

When he goes quiet. A silent sub may be trying to quit, and a gap of a week or two can be normal. A caring dom sends one short check-in at most, without inviting him back, and accepts that he may not answer. A sub who has quit gets no messages at all. Pushing won't make anyone admit what he wants to hide. ◆

When he quits. Respect it. Don't chase him, don't message him again, and wish him the life he wants. A line like "my door is always open" can also work as a soft hook, so leave it out. ◆

A friend outside the game. If a sub feels unloved, or valued only for his money, a friend elsewhere in the community who's easy to reach and steady can help. A friend is support, and doesn't replace professional help. ◆

Pressure moves to refuse when someone is low

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

01 *Joking that she'll leave, or go and help a rival*

THE COUNTER

Say right away that it was a joke, and never use leaving to steer spending. If someone does it to you, you can say it hurt and ask her to stop.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

02 *Using her own distress to keep him sending*

THE COUNTER

Her distress is for her own people to help with. It's never a reason for him to send.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

03 *Asking for a login or a verification code "to help"*

THE COUNTER

Refuse. A real dom never needs access.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

04 *A deadline on a decision about money*

THE COUNTER

A decision about money can wait one night.

WHAT THEY SAY OR DO

05 *A demand for a full written confession, with contact ended if he refuses*

THE COUNTER

Ask for a pause and a trusted third person. See If you already sent.

TRY IT

A goodbye that worries you

This is an invented exercise. A sub you know writes a message that says goodbye and hints that he may hurt himself. He doesn't answer when you reply.

A Treat it as a normal exit and give him space

Not this one. A goodbye that hints at self-harm is a crisis. Space is for a normal exit.

B Wait until morning, since it's late for him

Not this one. A late hour is no reason to wait. Write now.

C Write as a person, ask whether he's safe, ask him to contact emergency services or a helpline and someone near him, then tell someone you trust

The right answer. Right. Drop the persona, keep it calm and point him to help outside the game.

PART 06

For doms: look after yourself

V

VIVIAN'S FIELD NOTES

Doms and makers burn out. The signs: you put pressure on yourself, you dread opening the project, and nothing seems to work. Step back. Go private for a while, stop posting and stop starting new things for a few days or a week, and keep talking to the people already in your life. You can come back later. Replying less often can protect you, but it can also leave a sub alone at the worst time, so point him to help before you go quiet.

◆

One more rule for makers: never send hypnotic or trance-style content to someone who may be driving or operating anything, because it can cause an accident. ◆

REMEMBER IT

- A dom who’s paid by a sub can’t be his safety net.
- Stop, listen, ask for nothing, and point him to help outside the game.
- Talk of self-harm is a crisis: drop the persona and send him to emergency services, a helpline and someone near him.
- When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening.
- Refuse pressure moves, access requests and any deadline on a decision about money.

Free, confidential helplines exist in most countries.

Find a helpline →

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

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06 It should come from outside the money: a limit he set while he was calm and can't raise on the spot, a person who knows, and an independent service.

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09 She asks how he feels and lets him talk.

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10 When he says he's going downhill and wants to carry on another day, she agrees right away.

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11 If the sub says he feels he's buying affection, a decent dom tells him affection can't be bought.

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12 She's just as warm when he sends a little as when he sends a lot.

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13 Never treat it as a normal exit.

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14 Researchers who spoke to findommes report that some clients showed suicidal tendencies.

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Findommes, Cybermediated Sex Work, and Rinsing (McCracken and Brooks-Gordon, Sexuality Research and Social Policy 18(4), 837-854, DOI 10.1007/s13178-021-00609-3) (https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/PMC8418458/fullTextXML)

Archive (https://web.archive.org/web/20261016030740/https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8418458/)

Accessed 3 November 2026

15 If he goes silent after a message like that, it doesn't mean he's fine.

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16 A thank-you from him doesn't prove he's safe either.

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17 When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening.

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18 Some of these claims are false and some are true, and if she guesses wrong, the sub is the one who pays for it.

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19 Don't ask for more when he says money is short.

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20 Call it what it is: redirection.

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21 It puts the responsibility for the harm on the person who's already in trouble.

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22 It turns unsafe when it makes you stop trying to reach him.

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23 When the person who's paid offers to help him quit, treat that offer with suspicion.

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24 A silent sub may be trying to quit, and a gap of a week or two can be normal.

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25 A sub who has quit gets no messages at all.

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26 Pushing won't make anyone admit what he wants to hide.

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27 Don't chase him, don't message him again, and wish him the life he wants.

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28 A line like "my door is always open" can also work as a soft hook, so leave it out.

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29 If a sub feels unloved, or valued only for his money, a friend elsewhere in the community who's easy to reach and steady can help.

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31 Replying less often can protect you, but it can also leave a sub alone at the worst time, so point him to help before you go quiet.

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Find a helpline →

The Drawn Ledger 18+

Nothing here is financial, legal or medical advice for your situation.